

Bernays was a mastermind, but he wasn't alone in creating the consumer culture we see today. Edward Cowdrick, an economist, penned "the new economic gospel of consumption," promoting the idea that blue-collar families could be educated in the new "skills of consumption." And Charles Kettering, Director of Research at General Motors from 1920–1947, is said to have told his team to "[Pursue] constant improvement and change so that the customer will be stimulated to desire the new product enough to buy it to replace the one he has."

Over the last one hundred years, capitalism has preserved rapid growth for its shareholders by taking away our identities as people and turning us into consumers. Consumers with an unquenchable thirst for more. And it worked. The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics reported¹ that in 1901 families spent an average of 20 percent of their income on "non-necessities." A century later, in 2002, that figure was 50 percent. *Chicago Tribune* journalist Mary T. Schmich coined the term "retail therapy" in 1986 when she wrote, "We've become a nation measuring out our lives in shopping bags and nursing our psychic ills through retail therapy."

We think it's important to understand the history of consumerism in America not because we're anti-capitalism or because we want you to be angry about this systemic deception. But to remind you that many of your desires do not come from within. There are people in offices whose job it is to manipulate our good-intentioned desires and our insecurities to turn us into machines that are constantly seeking happiness. Marketing and advertising have conditioned us from birth to be dissatisfied with what we have and where we've been and believe the next new thing or place will be the solution. And it's led to a change in the chemical activity in our brains that makes it ever more appealing to spend.

Trained Monkeys

In her book *Dopamine Nation*, psychiatrist Dr. Anna Lembke recounts stories from her decades of treating patients for addiction. She's seen every kind of addiction, from the common to the NSFW (not safe for work). She even recounts her own short-lived addiction to romance novels, a high we've personally experienced once or twice . . . or more. The common thread she cites among all addictions is the release of dopamine.